

Weekly Reading Reflections #5: Sergio Monterroso

Hard History & Contested Narratives and Institutions

Hard History

There exist two dominant narratives to the Holocaust in Europe: one from the West and one from the East. The West's narrative focuses on their triumph over fascism, but the East's narrative has undergone changes. Previously, the Eastern narrative was that Communism succeeded over Nazism because of how Soviet satellite states needed this narrative to make their state authentic. After the collapse of the Soviet Union, their narrative began to change to equate Communism and Nazism as two of the worst evils, which the West disagreed to. To the West, Fascism was the most recent evil they experienced; to the East, that belonged to Communism. Controversies continued as the West refused to take responsibility for its complicity of Nazi rule but demanded that the East repent for its actions.

WWII History, what originally began as a review for understanding of a dark period for Europe, now became a politicized discourse between two sides of Europe. The biggest victim from this discourse is the tourist who tries to educate themselves about a tragedy that must be learned from, not politicized. It is difficult enough to bring a tourist to a site of unspeakable horror and ask them to learn about it, but to introduce European in-fighting makes the narrative even more difficult to follow. The West refuses to acknowledge how their refusal to accept Jewish immigrants from mainland Europe likely resulted in immense unnecessary deaths, or how Italian history places Germany as the main culpable party in the war. The East wants Stalin to be the new Hitler, which has a chance of diluting the evils of Nazism by placing another party beside it. Museum learning of WWII is next to impossible unless a tourist goes to multiple sites of differing narratives. Public History is made impossible to recognize because of its politics.

In class, we discussed why we do History as a discipline. Is it to assign responsibility of the Holocaust? Are Historians just investigators of the past who judge and assign culpability to groups based on their inquisitory reviews? Do we use History as a political narrative? Do we [the general public] use History as a political narrative? These are questions that are reflected in the hard history of the Holocaust, and how states and intergovernmental organizations like the European Union must politically handle the narratives associated with these tragedies to suit their needs and the needs of their member-states. Some people now just divorce the past because of how uncomfortable and politicized it is. The study of politics of public history is to bring nuance to these topics without losing the cohesion and significance – but also maintaining public attention to it. Through it all, the biggest loser seems to be history (lowercase).

Contested Narratives & Institutions

This reading is like the Hard History reading but instead of dealing with an event or tragedy, we deal with the heritage and its erasure by imperialism. Australian museums have a land acknowledgement which nods towards how indigenous lands were stolen and that they offer their sorrow for it. Abu-Lughod argues that this is a redirection of the issue of indigenous problems from a physical land problem to a cultural problem, which many

institutions have. In exchange for the acknowledgement and inclusion of indigenous culture in the institution, the indigenous population must essentially acquiesce their claims on the land or restitution. This is a very dark, but truthful, way to look at these land acknowledgement statements that surprised me and changed my look on them. Turning to the Palestinians, they actively fight against this compromise by liberation movements making actual demands for freedom instead of acknowledgments. Palestine is lighting a thousand fires, but the only fire lit for the Australian natives is the one lit by the settlers.

There are other objections on Palestinians becoming the next “indigenous” population, namely that it would require a freeze on their culture to be History-ified and that they’re still fighting for their interests. They seek not to be acknowledged, but to be corrected of the wronging they’ve faced. In terms of our class, even the inclusion of something in History is political and requires paying attention to the people that we are sentencing to live in the past. We’re now adding another aspect to politics of public history: the political discourse surrounding the “museumification” of certain peoples, and sentencing them to be “History-ified” to the annals of the past.